trying to see your reaction to such a statement. So you say it must be an unknown person. Who was that?'

It was now getting clear to me that these intelligence bureau men with visibly low intelligence had woven a story or an imaginary case of spying, but it was riddled with holes. They were seeking information to add muscle to that weak skeleton, with basic information about our working style and contacts. They wanted names, incidents and connections between them. They were constantly amending their story of fiction, and, in fact, I was inadvertently helping them make these changes to make their version a slightly less absurd one. I decided to stop clarifying and educating these morons, and stick to bare answers.

They kept asking for the name of the 'unknown person', I repeated that I had met no such person.

'Mr Nambi, you think you are smart,' he said. 'But you should understand that we are smarter. We have more than twenty-five years of experience in interrogation. We have cracked tougher nuts than you. We pray for our daily bread while you bastards sell national secrets to enemies to amass wealth.'

The scene here was deteriorating rapidly—and violently.

Now two others entered the room. One, a short dark man in spectacles, came straight to me and started hitting me on the face. I stood still, receiving the blows. Nobody, not even my father had ever hit me. My mind was drifting in a sea of humiliation, confusion and sadness. I felt no physical pain.

The man who hit me shouted if I am afraid of anyone. The other officer sprang up with an answer: 'Yes'.

I looked into his eyes and corrected him: 'No'.

The man in spectacles looked bewildered, stared me for a moment and walked away with his associate.

The Panama smoker came near me and whispered: 'Why are you getting bashed up? Why don't you tell us the truth and be spared?'

'Because I don't know any such person or any such deal.'